REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 01



AI Stalemate

THE PRODUCT MANAGER FIELD GUIDE

Make a credible case for the opportunity. Shape the next move with your lead.

Nic Payne

For you, the product manager

OPEN YOUR PRODUCT MANAGER LAB >

UNDERSTAND THE PRESSURE. WORK THE SITUATION. LEAVE WITH A MOVE.

WORKING EDITION / REBEL-LEADER.COM

You see an opportunity. Your lead sees a cost.

You want your team to move forward with AI. Your lead developer is not convinced. Before the next conversation, get specific about the outcome you want and curious about the work they would carry.

Start with the outcome you own

What would improve for your customers or your team? Faster drafting is one possible means. Name the customer wait, repeated task, missed learning, or capacity problem you actually want to change.

Ask your lead what they would carry

Your lead is accountable for what ships: quality, maintainability, data boundaries, and review. Ask which part of your proposal adds work or risk. Their answer may reveal how to improve it.

Keep the event separate from your story

Your lead declined a trial using customer data. That is an observation. They are afraid of change is an interpretation. Take the observable event into the conversation and ask for their account.

Make a proposal they can help shape

Try: I want to reduce the full effort of accepted work. Where might AI help, and what would we need to protect? Give your lead authority over technical suitability and the acceptance bar.

> Your win: lead a worthwhile opportunity with your developer, then explain the decision to the organization with evidence.

Paint a future worth working toward.

Before asking your lead to try a tool, get clear about your own Why. Paint a future they can recognize, then invite them to improve the picture with you.

Name the improvement you care about

As the PM, which customer or team outcome makes this worth pursuing? Name the problem, who experiences it, and why you care. Connect the AI proposal to that outcome.

Paint a recognizable before and after

Describe the future in everyday work: shorter customer waits, fewer repetitive tasks, more time for judgment, or patterns other teams can trust. Make the picture specific enough to question and improve.

Connect it to a shared stake

The company could gain a useful capability. The team could gain mastery and influence over its standards. Building something others trust could also create professional opportunities for both leaders.

Invite authorship

Ask your lead: What would responsible use look like here? What would you change in this picture? Let their judgment change the task, the conditions, and the approach.

Connect the picture to the next move

A vision gives the work direction. The next move makes it credible: clarify a concern, resolve permission or capacity, use existing evidence, or agree on one bounded test.

> Try: If we can find a responsible way to reduce repetitive work, we could give the team more time for the hard problems. We could help this company set a standard other teams trust, and create opportunities for both of us. I'd like us to shape that together. What would make it worth pursuing for you?

Make the concern workable.

When your lead raises a concern, ask what it means in this workflow. These questions help you turn the concern into a condition or change your proposal. Your lead owns technical suitability; you help make the investment and tradeoff explicit.

The quality is not good enough

Which checks or standards fail? Consider a smaller task, clearer acceptance criteria, repository conventions, automated tests, and human review. Keep the existing quality bar.

Reviewing it takes longer

Where does effort increase? Consider smaller changes, explicit author verification, and protected review time. Measure accepted work across the whole workflow rather than the first draft.

Our data or code cannot go into that tool

Which inputs and approvals are involved? Establish the permitted tool and input boundary with the approval owner. Synthetic or non-sensitive inputs may be an option; permission comes first.

It does not understand our codebase

Which context or conventions are missing? Consider explicit repository instructions, a known example, and a contained task. Check whether the available context actually supports that use.

We do not have capacity

What work would this replace, and who must review it? Ask the priority owner to protect time or decline the investment. Unplanned overtime is not the trial budget.

We tried it and it was worse

Which task, conditions, and result? Use that evidence. If a materially different use is proposed, name what changed and why another test would answer a useful question.

GitHub: Copilot best practices

Thoughtworks: reducing AI development friction

> The useful question is: Which condition would make this proposal workable, and who can decide it? Keep a specific no and an unsupported yes open to the same scrutiny.

Let's get ready to talk with your lead.

Take 5-10 minutes before you talk with your lead. These notes are yours. Get clear about your outcome and assumptions so you can arrive curious, with a proposal worth discussing.

What happened with your lead developer?

Use the request, words, or event you can describe. Be precise enough that the other person could recognize it.

What are you assuming about your lead's motives?

Name your interpretation of their motive. Hold it as a hypothesis rather than a fact.

What customer or team outcome are you trying to protect?

Describe the opportunity, cost, obligation, or outcome you carry. Product and Engineering can both have legitimate answers.

What evidence have you seen yourself?

Separate a concrete past result from a prediction about future use. An observed failure deserves attention; it does not settle every use case.

What would change your mind about this use of AI?

Name the evidence that could alter your view. A trial is not useful if neither side would reconsider anything.

What do you need to ask your lead before proposing a trial?

Leave room for their actual account of the cost. Do not turn private preparation into a better argument for your original position.

> The Lab excludes every private-preparation field from the Trial Card, Evidence Record, and Decision Brief.

One test you could both believe.

Invite your lead into about 30 minutes of shared design. Bring the outcome and make room for their conditions. Use existing evidence if it answers the question; ask for a trial when there is a useful uncertainty to resolve.

Agree on the ambition

Share the future you hope to help create and why it matters. Ask the other leader to shape it. Record only the ambition you both agree to pursue in shared work.

Bound the work

Name the work outcome, exact task, and work that is out of scope. Choose a comparator without AI and say why the task size, experience, and acceptance bar are comparable.

Set the permission boundary

Ask your lead to confirm the tool, model/version, permitted inputs, and approval owner. A leadership request does not grant permission to use an unapproved tool or sensitive inputs.

Protect quality and capacity

Ask your lead to define acceptance checks. Help protect author and reviewer time by naming what work moves. If the priority decision belongs to someone else, take that tradeoff to them.

Agree on the bar beforehand

Define success across the full workflow, not just generation speed. Write a stop rule that can be acted on during the trial.

Make ownership explicit

Name the task owner, reviewer, decision owner, and review date. Export the Trial Card now, before the test. If a prerequisite is missing, name it and choose PAUSE.

> A good trial: one approved unit-test task with comparable work and reserved review time. A weak trial: Everyone use AI this week and report whether it felt faster.

Count the work on both sides.

When the result comes back, ask about everyone's work. Count setup, verification, review, rework, and follow-up alongside drafting. You need accepted work at a defensible full cost to make a case to leadership.

Workflow stage	Without AI	With AI
Setup / context	10 min	15 min
Drafting	45 min	12 min
Author verification	15 min	25 min
Reviewer checking	15 min	30 min
Rework	5 min	15 min
Follow-up	0 min	0 min
Total person-minutes	**90 min**	**97 min**

The worked example

These fictional measurements describe one matched unit-test task. The acceptance bar passed after rework. Drafting was faster with AI, while verification, review, and rework increased.

What the totals establish

Drafting took 33 fewer minutes, but the full recorded workflow took 7 more. Reviewer checking increased by 15 minutes. The agreed effort bar was missed in this local test.

What remains outside the totals

Record acceptance checks, defects, reviewer experience, tool cost, elapsed time, first-use learning, and limits to comparability. Name an owner and date for a later defect check.

> A complete total is useful evidence. It is not a universal AI productivity claim, a quality verdict, or proof of causation.

Four legitimate next moves.

Review the evidence with your lead and the agreed decision owner. Explain what this particular test supports, what remains uncertain, and the next action you are asking the organization to support.

CONTINUE

The evidence supports this bounded use under these conditions. Record the operating boundaries and the next review. Continue does not mean AI everywhere.

REVISE

The use may have value, but the task, inputs, review workflow, or boundaries need to change. Name what will change before another approved trial.

STOP

The evidence does not support this use, or a guardrail was breached. Record why and preserve what was learned. There is no obligation to turn a failed use case into adoption.

PAUSE

A prerequisite, approval, owner, capacity, or useful evidence is missing. Name the prerequisite and who will resolve it. Pause can be chosen before a trial starts.

> Every decision needs a reason, the limits of the evidence, an accountable next-action owner, and a date. Record unresolved disagreement rather than claiming consensus.

From an argument to a defensible move.

Here is what you can take back to your boss after working with your lead. Faster drafting did not mean less total effort. Both leaders changed the proposal instead of defending their first positions.

The Trial Card

Outcome: reduce the effort of producing accepted unit tests. Task: one isolated unit-test task; production code and customer data are out of scope. Use an approved tool with synthetic fixtures and a recorded version.

The shared bar

Preserve the existing test review and CI checks. Reserve author and reviewer time. Success requires lower total effort without transferring additional checking to the reviewer. Stop for unapproved inputs or a failed quality guardrail.

The Evidence Record

Without AI: 90 person-minutes. With AI: 97. The quality bar passed after rework, but reviewer checking doubled from 15 to 30 minutes. One local task does not establish a general gain or loss.

The Decision Brief

REVISE. The current workflow transfers too much work to review. The engineering lead will narrow the task and review workflow before approving another trial, with a named review date.

The update to leadership

Our first test passed quality after rework but used 97 person-minutes versus 90 without AI. We are revising the review workflow before testing again.

> They did not leave with agreement about AI in general. They left with a specific decision, its evidence, and a next action.

Take this into the work.

Use the Guide to prepare your judgment, then open your PM Lab to work the situation in front of you. Nic's walkthrough shows the same process on a realistic example.

1. Prepare privately

Open Private Prep in the PM Lab. Write what happened, your Why, the future you want to help create, and what you still need to ask your lead.

2. Build and export the Trial Card

Move to Shared Work. Agree on the task, comparator, permission, quality, capacity, bar, stop rule, owners, and review date. Export the Trial Card before the test.

3. Return with evidence

Enter full-workflow effort for both methods, quality results, and comparison limits. Export the Evidence Record. Blank effort stays unknown.

4. Write the decision

Choose Continue, Revise, Stop, or Pause. Name the reason, limits, next action, owner, date, and leadership update. Copy, download, or print the Decision Brief.

Keep what matters

Drafts live in this browser on this device. Export important work before clearing browser data or changing devices. There is no cloud backup or synchronized team workspace in this edition.

> Want to rehearse first? Watch Nic work through a complete case, then load the fictional example in the Lab before bringing your own situation.